

ANYTHING GOES

The sixties were optimistic, upbeat, and occasionally turbulent. The new mood of freedom and rampant individualism was reflected in fashion. Younger designers in Britain such as Mary Quant and John Bates, Marion Foale and Sally Tuffin, Caroline Charles and Jean Muir, and also those in France, including André Courrèges, Emanuel Ungaro, and Pierre Cardin, had all been experimenting with more youthful styles for young women who no longer accepted that they had to dress like their mothers. From such beginnings the miniskirt was born in 1964. Hems rose swiftly, until by 1967 styles were thigh-high. Stockings with suspenders could no longer be worn, and so manufacturers developed all-in-one tights, or pantyhose as they were then known.

In fashion once an extreme is reached then a reaction sets in. The miniskirt could get no higher, so designers brought out new skirt lengths: first of all the midi, followed by the more enduring maxi. At the same time the miniskirt still survived, and trouser suits, polo-necked jumpers, and hipster jeans – part of a “unisex” trend – were being worn. By the end of the decade it was a case of anything goes.

“Once only the Rich, the Establishment set the fashion. Now it is the inexpensive little dress seen on the girls in the High Street. These girls...are alive...looking, listening, ready to try anything new...they represent the whole new spirit...”

GEORGE MELLY, *REVOLT INTO STYLE*, 1972

◀ CHANGING TIMES

Fashion in the 1960s was evolving at breakneck speed, as demonstrated by the breadth of styles modelled at the opening of Just Looking, one of the numerous boutiques that mushroomed in the King's Road and Carnaby Street, London.

